

device out there. It allows the phone to override certain layouts when screen space is constrained and even provides libraries to provide backward compatibility for older versions of Android. The sheer diversity of devices available in the market ensures that any person looking for a phone can find one to meet his exact requirements, whether it's for a power user looking for the most powerful hardware to hack into or the average user who wants to use it as a bare-bones communication device. Indeed, Android has even been ported to devices such as portable media players, cameras and even a coffee-vending machine! All this portability is possible only because of the open source nature of the platform.



The Kindle Fire, running Amazon's custom skin atop Android was an instant success

A level-playing field

Android has succeeded in creating a level-playing field for hardware vendors and handset manufacturers by letting them focus on what they do best—the hardware of the device. This approach has proven to work very well with many manufacturers, particularly Samsung, HTC and Motorola. While Samsung is currently ruling the roost thanks its Galaxy range of smartphones, the wildly successful Motorola Droid was instrumental in reviving the fortunes of the ailing company. Today Android occupies a larger market share than Apple's iOS in the US, and Samsung is the world's largest smartphone manufacturer. The ultimate winner is the end-user who is faced with nearly endless options while buying a phone.

Android on Tablets

Android tablets experienced a very different fate from Android phones. The lack of dedicated apps that could take advantage of the tablet's larger display meant that most apps looked stretched on a tablet. Developers failed to recognize the potential of the tablet market and didn't start paying attention to tablet-specific apps until much later, when the iPad had gained a significant